

The essentials of Indian credit card rewards on one sheet — the rules that separate people who quietly win from people who leave money on the table.

The 5 Golden Rules

- › Pay the TOTAL due, never the minimum. Carrying a balance costs 30–48%/yr and erases every reward.
- › Never withdraw cash on a credit card. Interest from day one, no grace period, plus a fee.
- › Match the card to the spend. Use the right card per category — no single card wins everywhere.
- › Keep utilisation under 30% of your limit. It's ~30% of your CIBIL score.
- › Redeem regularly. Points expire (usually 2–3 yrs) and devalue over time. Burn, don't hoard.

Redemption Value Ladder

Air miles / hotel transfers	Best
Flights & hotels via bank portal	Rs 1/pt
Gift vouchers	~Rs 0.50/pt
Statement credit	~Rs 0.30/pt
Product catalogue	~Rs 0.20/pt - avoid

Rule of thumb: 1 point is worth what you get on travel — everything below that is the bank hoping you settle for less.

Best Card by Spend

Online shopping

Category cashback card

Dining & food delivery

10% cashback card (e.g. Live+)

Flights & hotels

Premium travel + transfers

Fuel

Fuel surcharge-waiver card

Everyday / groceries

Flat cashback card

Rent

Usually not worth it — check fees

International

Low-forex card (1.99% or less)

Points Expiry — Quick Table

HDFC super-premium	3 yrs
HDFC (other) / SBI	2 yrs
Axis EDGE	3 yrs
ICICI	2–3 yrs
Amex / IDFC First	Never*
Airline / hotel	18–24 mo idle

*While the account stays active. Points forfeit on card closure.



Costly Traps to Avoid

- › Paying only the minimum due — years of debt at 30–48%.
- › Cash advances — no grace period, fee + instant interest.
- › Letting points expire — pure profit for the bank ("breakage").
- › Closing old cards — raises utilisation, cuts credit age, hurts CIBIL.
- › Product-catalogue redemptions — often just Rs 0.20/pt.
- › Forgetting fee-waiver spends — many fees waive at a threshold.
- › Buying on Amazon/Flipkart with the wrong card — some cards exclude them.

CIBIL Quick Facts

- › Payment history ~35% · Utilisation ~30% are the big two.
- › Checking your own score = zero impact (soft inquiry).
- › Each application = a hard inquiry (5–10 pt temp dip).
- › Carrying a balance does NOT help your score. Myth.

Sale & Timing Calendar

Big sale season

Amazon GIF + Flipkart BBD (late Sep–Oct)

Prime Day

Mid-year (Jul)

Stack for max value

Card offer + coupon + no-cost EMI + co-brand

Before you buy

Check the running card-offer list for the sale

Monthly 5-Min Checklist

- ☐ Pay statement in FULL by the due date
- ☐ Keep utilisation under 30%
- ☐ Check for points nearing expiry
- ☐ Redeem at Rs 1/pt or better
- ☐ Track progress to any fee-waiver
- ☐ Watch for devaluation announcements

Go deeper — free tools

Points value calculator · Card quiz · Fee breakeven · Interest calculator · CIBIL utilisation checker

pointsmax.in